



THE WORLD IS YOURS

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NEGOTIATED UNDERSTANDING — MULTI-SCREEN DIGITAL VIDEO · 8-CHANNEL SOUND INSTALLATION

Warehouse XI, Somerville MA · 2024 work / 2026 exhibition design · portfolio & case study · wis-coral.vercel.app

Does understanding survive the handover?

BACKGROUND

We live, more than ever, on other people's experience — reviews, guides, patient stories, the advice of AI. It circulates day and night as content, evidence, care, and data.

This circulation assumes experience can be spoken, heard, and handed over whole.

Yet understanding begins from a partial position. We know more than we can tell; language carries only the surface.

Understanding was never a handover — it is negotiation: guessing, misreading, repairing, until: I think I understand.

We asked blind and low-vision friends to describe their worlds, and translated those descriptions into moving images. Not the subject — the most honest case:

the same negotiation happens in every act of telling and listening.

THE CIRCULATION — HOW THE WORLD ARRIVES SECOND-HAND

reviews · 82% — Pew 2016

health stories · 72% — Pew 2013

AI advice · 34% — Pew 2025

live description · 10M — Be My Eyes



RESEARCH

two layers, never interchanged

Field data — fifteen short interviews and a bilingual micro-survey (N=23) — is small and qualitative. Six anchors from representative surveys and controlled experiments stand beside it.

The instrument asks what happened the last time — dependence, distortion, the limits of telling. No questions about blindness; no questions about beliefs.

A second, co-creation protocol with blind collaborators runs in two visits: a day walked inside their world, then a translation-proofing session where drafts return to be corrected.

SIX ANCHORS FROM THE LITERATURE

[1] Pew Research 2016 — 82% read reviews before buying (N=4,787).

[2] Pew Research 2013 — 72% sought health information online.

[3] Pew Research 2025 — 34% have used ChatGPT (N=5,123).

[4] Savitsky et al., JESP 2011 — couples ≈ strangers in accuracy, far more confident.

[5] Eyal, Steffel & Epley, JPSP 2018 — imagining fails ×25; asking works.

[6] WHO 2019 · Be My Eyes — 2.2B vision-impaired; 1M users × 10M volunteers.

FROM THE QUOTE WALL

34 answers to “the thing I can never describe is...”

...the smell of rain before it

starts.

...the way my mother says my

name.

...what missing someone does at

night.

...the taste, however well AI

describes it.

...it vanishes before I even

notice it.

...sincerity.

From field notes to a negotiated field

Short interviews (N=15) and a bilingual micro-survey (N=23), July 2026 — asked what happened the last time, not what people believe. Drawn one person at a time.

FIG.01 / ONE STEM PER PERSON

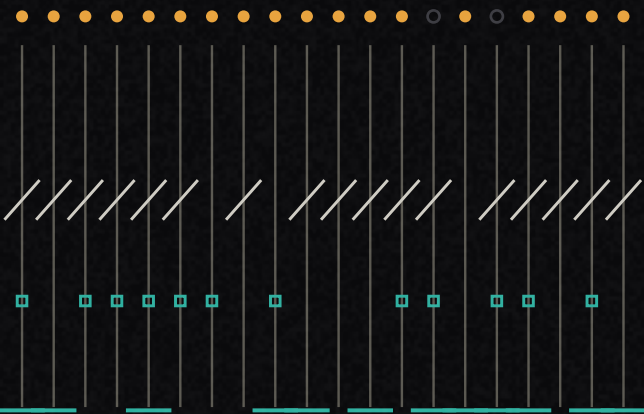


FIG.02 / SAID IS NOT HEARD

72

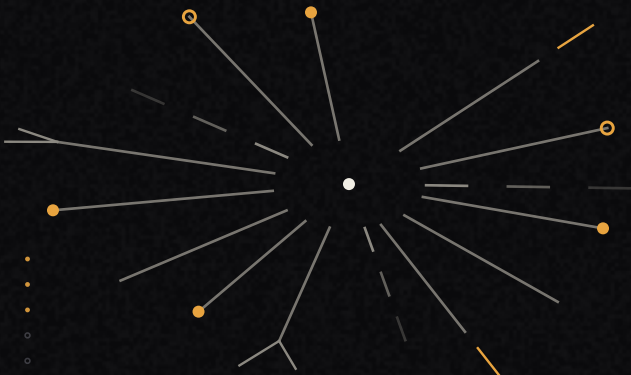
believed through



61

actually heard

FIG.03 / SIX ENDINGS



01 Field survey

One stem per person: 18/20 acted on

others' experience this week; 17/20

followed it and it turned out

different; 12/20 asked AI; 12/20

feel the gap behind “I understand

you.”

02 The leak

Speakers believed 72 of 100

utterances got through; listeners

actually heard 61. Overestimating

understanding is the norm, not a

personal failure. (Keysar & Henly

2002)

Anchors: Pew 2016/2013/2025 · Savitsky 2011 · Eyal/Epley 2018 · WHO / Be My Eyes.

Field data is small and qualitative; the anchors are representative or controlled— side by side, never interchanged.

[RESEARCH PLATE · FOUR REFERENCES SUPPORTING THIS STRUCTURE]



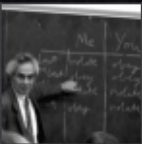
REF-01

Michael Polanyi

“The Weak Dimension,” 1966 —

“we can know more than we can tell.”

PUBLIC DOMAIN · WIKIMEDIA



REF-02

Thomas Nagel

“What is it like to be a Bat?”,

1974 — the partial position.

CC BY-SA · WIKIMEDIA



REF-03

Ludwig Wittgenstein

“I guess, 1930 — I had shared

word, unverifiable contents.

PUBLIC DOMAIN · WIKIMEDIA



REF-04

Walter Benjamin

experience compressed into

information.

PUBLIC DOMAIN · WIKIMEDIA

[FIELD ARTIFACTS — A5 SURVEY · QUOTE WALL, 34 ANSWERS]



Asking, not imagining

FIELD INTERVIEWS — N = 15

Fifteen short interviews asked what happened the last time — the last time you relied on someone’s experience, the last time telling failed — never what people believe about understanding. Everyone was interviewed; blindness was never mentioned: the point is that the condition is universal.

A second, co-creation protocol with blind collaborators runs in two visits: a day walked together inside their world, then a translation-proofing session where drafts return to be corrected — “what I assumed” set against “what they said.”

“I can describe anything. But if the other person cannot fully understand it — have I really finished describing?”

P13

“However well AI describes it, it cannot make you taste it.”

P15

“It disappears before I even notice it.”

FROM THE QUOTE WALL — 34 ANSWERS TO “THE THING I CAN NEVER DESCRIBE IS...”

“Forget it. It doesn’t matter.”

P11 — ENDING A CONVERSATION WITH HER THERAPIST

The shortest answer on the quote wall, and its last word: “Sincerity.”

How conversations end

●	“I think I understand.”	·4
	the negotiated good-enough ending	
— — —	“Forget it.”	·3
	giving up on being understood	
<	Agree to differ	·2
	negotiating an end to negotiation	
○	Pretend to understand	·2
	the social performance	
— —	Look it up later	·2
	understanding privatised	
⤿	“As long as you’re happy.”	·2
	ending with a blessing	

“Sweet like sugar — but the small part that isn’t sugar is usually the part that matters.”

P13, ON HONEY — THE GOOD-ENOUGH THEORY OF UNDERSTANDING, FROM THE FIELD

Interview instrument: three families of “last time” prompts — dependence, distortion, the limits of telling. No questions about blindness; no questions about beliefs.

THE INSTRUMENT

01 DEPENDENCE

“When did you last act on someone else’s experience?”

02 DISTORTION

“You followed it. What turned out different?”

03 LIMITS

“What can you never quite put into words?”

TWO VISITS

01 — a day walked inside their world

02 — drafts return, corrected line by line

FIFTEEN CONVERSATIONS — CODED

● ○ — — < ● ⤿ ● <

— — — — — ⤿ ● — — — — — ○ — — — — —

each mark = one interview, by ending

THE WORK — 2024

Eleven films grown from spoken worlds

We asked blind and low-vision friends to describe their worlds, then translated those descriptions into moving images. In the room the films are the size of a hand — you must walk close to see; eight voices fill the dark from eight corners, and every voice ends on the same sentence.



STILLS — films 09 · 05 · 03: the doorway, steles in fog, brightness that refuses

IN THE ROOM

SCREENS

15 positions on floor stands, 0.6–1.9 m — the height of a hand held out

LOOPS

four of the eleven films loop on two screens each

SILENT

the films carry no sound; seeing and hearing are negotiated separately

SCALE

each image roughly the size of a postcard — you must walk close

“However well AI describes it, it cannot make you taste it.” — P15

ELEVEN READINGS



01 The Crane and the Moon

Someone described the moon as something near — near enough to install. So we hung it.



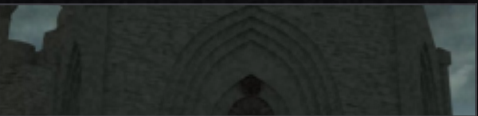
02 The Threshold

Half of it is not yet said; half already understood. The border keeps moving, and dust crosses through the light.



03 Brightness That Refuses

That brightness is not for seeing — it forces the eyes shut. Only when he said “bright” did we learn that brightness can refuse.



04 A Cathedral Overheard

A building never visited, built from adjectives overheard. The grain of the stone is the residue of other people’s voices.



05 Steles in Fog

Grass to the knee, steles in fog. A shape without a name can still be remembered — remembering how it feels is enough.



06 Assemblage at Dusk

A column, pipes, a cracked tub: sentences from different people piled into one dusk. None is whole; together they resemble a home.



07 The Wire Sphere

The thing inside can’t be explained — only that it burns, and that wire wraps around it. The fire is small; it stays lit.



08 A Planet on No Map

The world he spoke of is on no map. Fine — give it a glowing horizon and a few yellow moons. It is wherever you say it is.



09 The Doorway

She stands in the doorway; beyond it, a sky described to her a thousand times. Seeing was never something we could finish on her behalf.



10 Two Cats

Two cats on a white city, watching the sun go down. Neither explains orange to the other. Some company precedes understanding, and asks for none.



11 Daytime Through Paper

The whole world gauzed in yellow, like light seen through paper. He said: this is my daytime. So we placed the camera inside the paper, too.

The readings are the translators’ second readings — not quotations; some films combine several storytellers. All eleven films playable online.

EIGHT VOICES

Eight channels occupy eight corners of a dark room; they never pair with the screens. To see, you walk to an image; to listen, you stand where the channels balance.

No position lets you do both at once — seeing and hearing must be negotiated separately, step by step.



Combined stereo reference 11:09. In the room the voices play as eight independent sources. The sound layer is complete in itself: for blind and low-vision visitors it is the entire work, and the images are its translation into light.

CH1–CH8 · sources at 2.05 m, corners and mid-walls · positions indicative until commissioning

0000 0000 0000 0000

Every voice ends on the same sentence.

0000 0000 0000 0000



Installation view, 2024 — two original neon works return in the new staging.

SITE — rejected twice, chosen once

The venue is an argument: the mechanics of the work dictate the room. Three Boston-area candidates were surveyed and measured; two were rejected for reasons that define what the work is.

01 BCA Cyclorama — rejected

A 4,600-seat-scale rotunda. The volume forces large projections: walk-close-to-see dies at that scale, and the dome smears eight discrete channels into wash. Grand, and wrong.

02 Plaza Black Box — rejected

Clean darkness, but a seating system makes it a theatre: an audience faces a stage. The work needs a room you wander and negotiate, not a show you watch.

03 Warehouse XI — chosen

A raw white-brick hall in Somerville: no theatrical apparatus, day-rate hire, one room that takes the whole route. The single work item: blacking out the glass front—darkness must be built, which is true to the work.

ROUTE

- 01 south double doors in
- 02 buffer, foreword wall
- 03 west gap, into the dark
- 04 star field, wander
- 05 north-west opening
- 06 echo, along the braille wall
- 07 east door, card in hand
- 08 lounge, card opened
- 09 south exit — the brightest

SURVEY / MEASURED ON SITE

MAIN HALL

21.9 × 9.0 m — 198 sqm

star field · 15 screens

LOUNGE

17.5 × 4.4 m — 76 sqm

bright exit · readings

SMALL HALL

7.0 × 4.2 m — 29 sqm

echo · braille wall

CEILING

4.2 m clear

blackout rig height

Floor measurements from the venue's National Floor

Plans survey, verified

against the author's CAD;

door positions to be

confirmed on site.

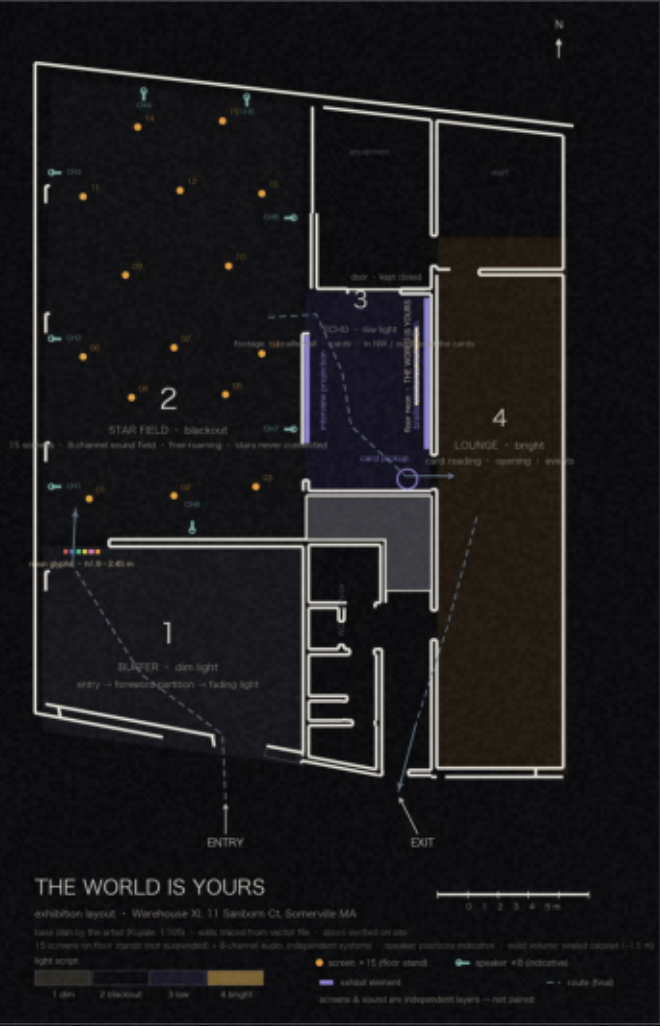


FIG.04 / PLAN — black-line, from the author's CAD

four zones · 15 screens · 8 channels · final route

EXHIBITION DESIGN

Four halls, one light script — the exit is the brightest place in the building

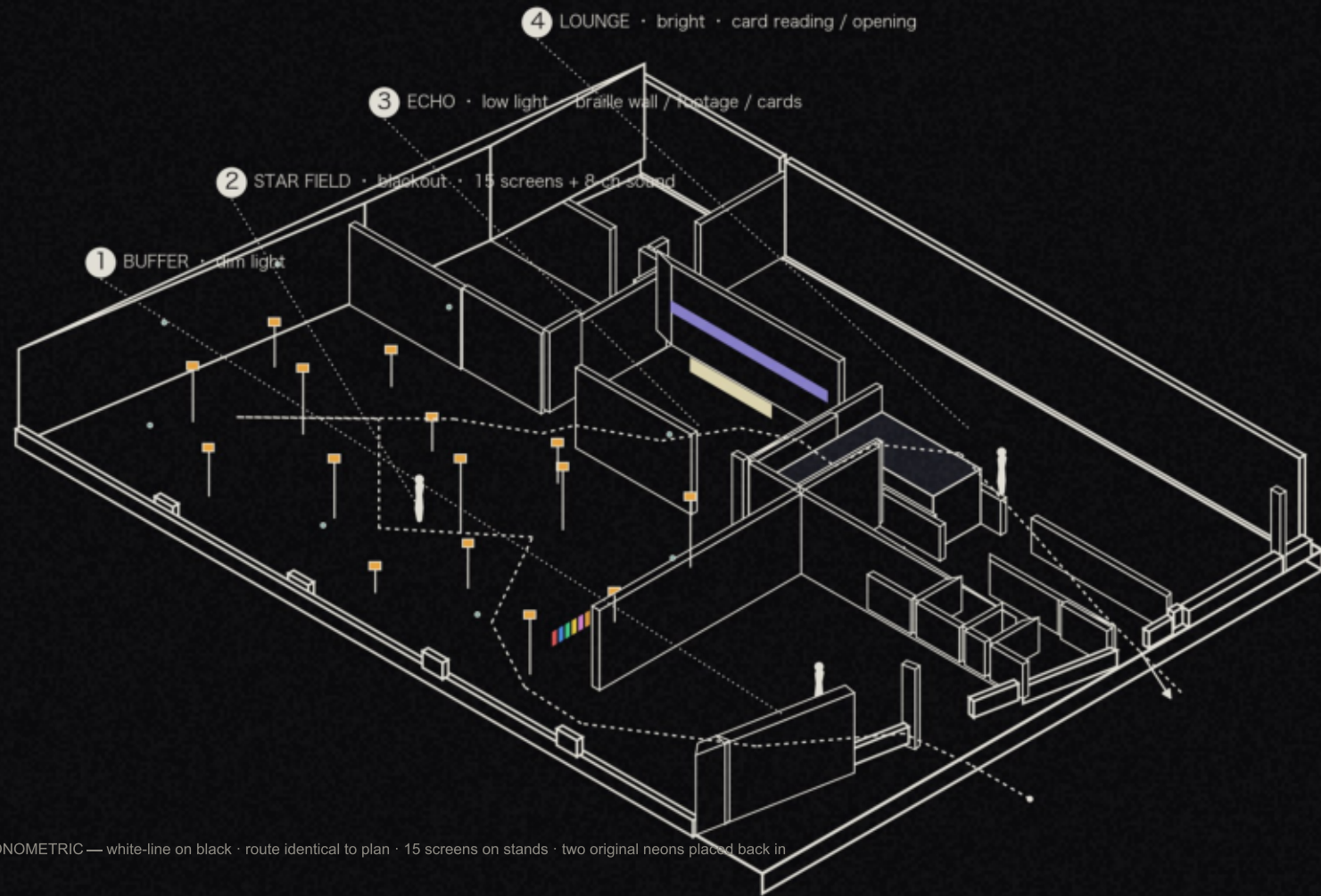


FIG.05 / AXONOMETRIC — white-line on black · route identical to plan · 15 screens on stands · two original neons placed back in

01 BUFFER · dim

A little light on the foreword wall only. Eyes adapt; the room empties of images before the field begins.

02 STAR FIELD · blackout

Fifteen screens on stands at hand height, 0.6–1.9 m. From afar: a field of small stars, never joined into constellations. Walk close to see; stand still to listen.

03 ECHO · low

A five-metre braille sentence wall at 1.05–1.38 m; interview footage projected; a card taken in the dark — braille on the front, unreadable where you receive it.

04 LOUNGE · bright

The card is opened: ink translation on the back. Readings, opening events; the sentence finally printed in full light.

THE CARD IS OPENED IN THE LOUNGE

The sentence appears three times: braille wall in half-dark, embossed card front, ink translation in the light.

1 BUFFER

dim · ~5 lux

2 STAR FIELD

blackout · <1 lux

3 ECHO

low · ~20 lux

4 LOUNGE

bright · ~300 lux

LIGHT SCRIPT

the page order of the building

05 Safety & access

45-minute sessions, max 25 visitors; photoluminescent guidance, red torches, life-safety lighting confirmed with Somerville FD. Guided touch-route sessions; the sound layer is complete without the images.

06 Materials

Braille-embossed ticket; A6 guide with braille pages beside ink pages. Three fabrication gates: grade decided with blind collaborators, tone-mark proofreading, tactile sign-off on physical proofs.

07 The card

Taken in half-dark, read in full light — a pocket-size rehearsal of negotiated understanding.

A6 GUIDE — CONTENTS

Cover · Foreword · Visiting in the dark · The four halls · The voices · The images · The sentence · Credits & access statement — braille pages bound beside ink pages, same paper weight.

THE CARD — 74 × 105 mm

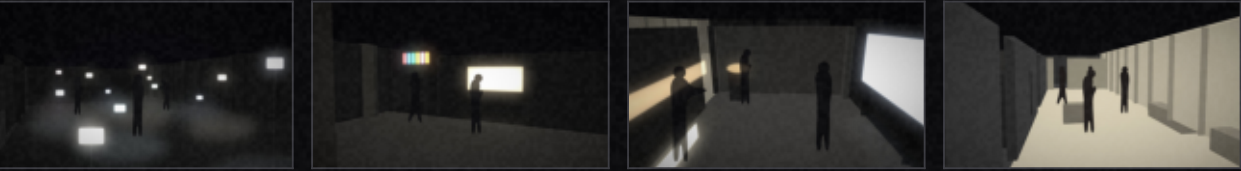
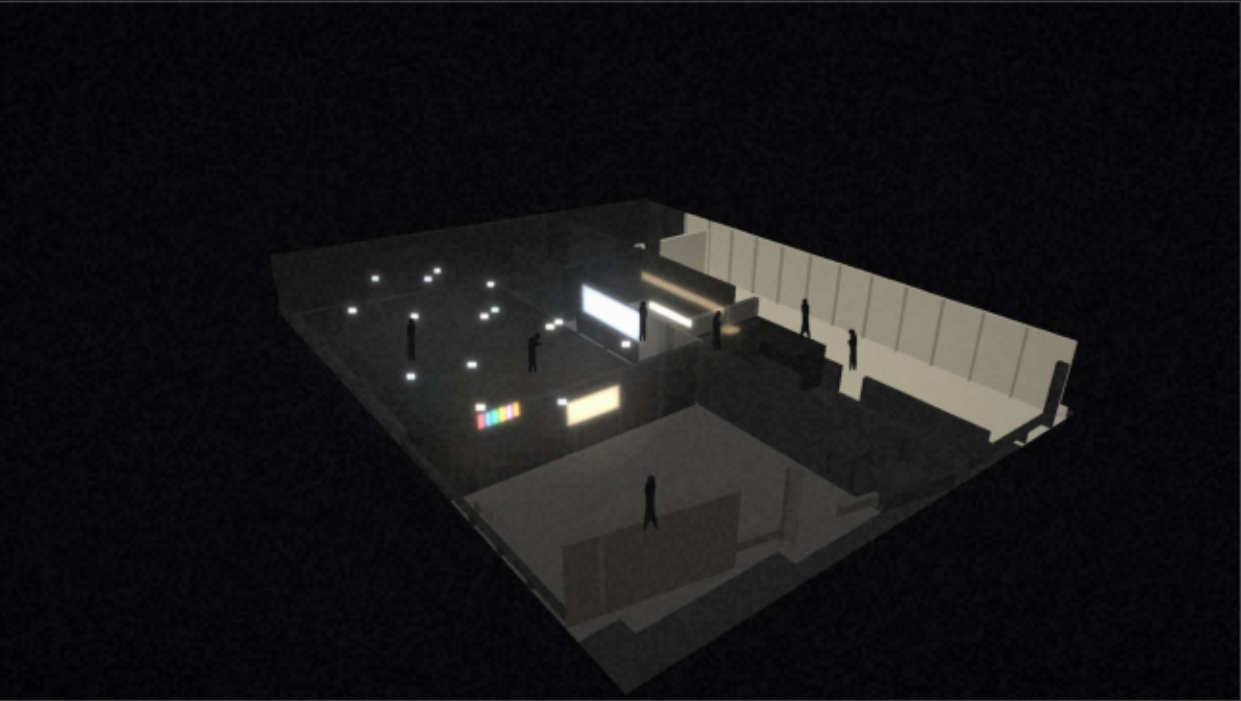


front: braille only

back: ink, in the light

THE ROOMS

digital visualizations from the layout data · not photographs



overview — dollhouse cut · star field eye level · buffer · echo · lounge

Renders share the drawings' pipeline: walls extracted from the CAD, zone light levels from the script, figures posed at true screen positions.

ONLINE EXHIBITION

A web version rebuilt in web-native language: a cinematic index of eleven films, each opening full-screen with slow crossfades; a black room where the eight voices surface while equalizer lines breathe; the sentence in neon. English and Chinese pages; the case study carries the research, drawings and this PDF.

→ wis-coral.vercel.app

case study · /case source · github.com/acrux-yueyao/wis

01 Index

Typographic list; a video preview follows the cursor; click into a one-film-at-a-time watch mode.

02 Voices

Stand-still-to-listen is translated to the page: the audio surfaces, the lines move.

03 Case

Research figures, literature anchors, drawings, renders, and the downloadable portfolio.

THE WORLD IS YOURS

The world is
yours.

THE WORLD IS YOURS

It may be a gift, a trust handed over, or the version least likely to be misunderstood. We cannot tell which — and the work refuses to decide.

11

films

© THE WORLD IS YOURS · Negotiated Understanding · multi-screen digital video, 8-channel sound installation · with gratitude to the storytellers who lent this work their worlds.

8

channels

15

screens

5 m

braille wall

45 min

sessions

25

visitors max